Lori Laitman (b.1955)
Four Dickinson Songs

Emily Dickinson (1830-1886)

Soprano Voice
Piano Accompaniment
(Original Keys)

Catalog No.
CVR 3229

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Lori Laitman is one of America's most prolific and widely performed composers of vocal music. She has composed two operas, an oratorio and over 200 songs, setting the words of classical and contemporary poets, among them the lost voices of poets who perished in the Holocaust. *"It is difficult to think of anyone before the public today who equals her exceptional gifts for embracing a poetic text and giving it new and deeper life through music." (The Journal of Singing)*

Laitman's full-length opera, *The Scarlet Letter*, to a new libretto of the Hawthorne classic by American poet David Mason, was commissioned and performed by the University of Central Arkansas in 2008 to critical acclaim. Excerpts from the opera were showcased at the Opera America Salon Series in New York in September 2010, and an announcement regarding the 2013 professional premiere of the opera will be made in early 2011. Laitman's one-act opera, *Come to Me in Dreams*, was premiered by Cleveland Opera in 2004, and her oratorio, *Vedem*, a commission by Music of Remembrance (another collaboration with poet David Mason), saw its world premiere in May of 2010 in Seattle, WA. *Vedem* will be released on the Naxos label in May 2011. Meanwhile, Laitman and Mason are poised to embark on their next project, the creation of a new opera based on *Ludlow*, Mason's award-winning epic verse novel.

In February 2010, Laitman was the Featured Composer on Thomas Hampson's new online resource, Song of America. In October 2010, the composer was the guest of The International Conservatory Week Festival at the St. Petersburg Conservatory in Russia, where she presented performances of her music and conducted a master class.

Many of Laitman's songs have entered the standard repertoire, including her settings of Abraham Sutzkever's poems from the Vilna ghetto, *The Seed of Dream* (2004). Naxos released the recording, which was pronounced "a masterpiece that should not be missed!" *(The Journal of Singing).* In 2009, acclaimed Austrian baritone Wolfgang Holzmair performed the cycle in his native Austria and subsequently commissioned Laitman. Other celebrated artists are programming Laitman's works, including countertenor Brian Asawa, soprano Elizabeth Futral and baritone Rodney Gilfry.

Since launching her career in 1991, Laitman's music has been performed frequently in the U.S. and abroad. Some recent U.S. venues include The Frye Art Music and Benaroya Hall in Seattle, WA; The Kennedy Center and The Phillips Collection in Washington, DC; Weill Recital Hall and Merkin Hall in New York, NY; The Granada in Santa Barbara, CA and The USC Fisher Museum in Los Angeles, CA.

Her discography continues to grow and her four solo CDs have received enthusiastic reviews. The composer's latest, *Within These Spaces* (2009), is receiving exceptional praise: "One hundred years hence, when critics look back at the art songs of our era, there will be many fine composers to laud and applaud, but few will deserve higher praise than Lori Laitman." *(The Journal of Singing)*; "This is music of depth and richness that connects with the soul." *(American Record Guide);* "Her affinity for the voice…is beyond doubt…her songs represent outpourings of great beauty." *(Fanfare Magazine).*

Laitman graduated magna cum laude from Yale College and received her Master of Music degree in flute performance from The Yale School of Music. Her recordings are available through her website, artsongs.com, and on Amazon and ITunes.

For more information, please visit artsongs.com and scarletletteropera.com.

Four Dickinson Songs
Poems by Emily Dickinson

In the spring of 1996 I composed *Four Dickinson Songs*. The combination of these poems allows for dramatic musical contrasts within the cycle. The wistful *Will There Really Be A Morning?* gives way to the humorous and bouncy *I'm Nobody*. The elegiac ambience of *She Died* is created by a spare opening piano accompaniment that later alternates with fluid meters. *If I...* was composed as a gift for my father's 80th birthday. Its simple, accessible melody passes from voice to piano and back again before ending with the singer humming.

1. Will There Really Be A Morning?

Will there really be a "Morning"?
Is there such a thing as "Day"?
Could I see it from the mountains
If I were as tall as they?

Has it feet like Water lilies?
Has it feathers like a Bird?
Is it brought from famous countries
Of which I have never heard?

Oh some Scholar! Oh some Sailor!
Oh some Wise Man from the skies!
Please to tell a little Pilgrim
Where the place called "Morning" lies!

2. I'm Nobody

I'm Nobody! Who are you?
Are you — Nobody — Too?
Then there's a pair of us!
Don't tell! they'd advertise — you know!

How dreary — to be — Somebody!
How public — like a Frog —
To tell one's name — the livelong June —
To an admiring Bog!

3. She Died

She died —*this* was the way she died.
And when her breath was done
Took up her simple wardrobe
And started for the sun.
Her little figure at the gate
The Angels must have spied,
Since I could never find her
Upon the mortal side.

4. If I...
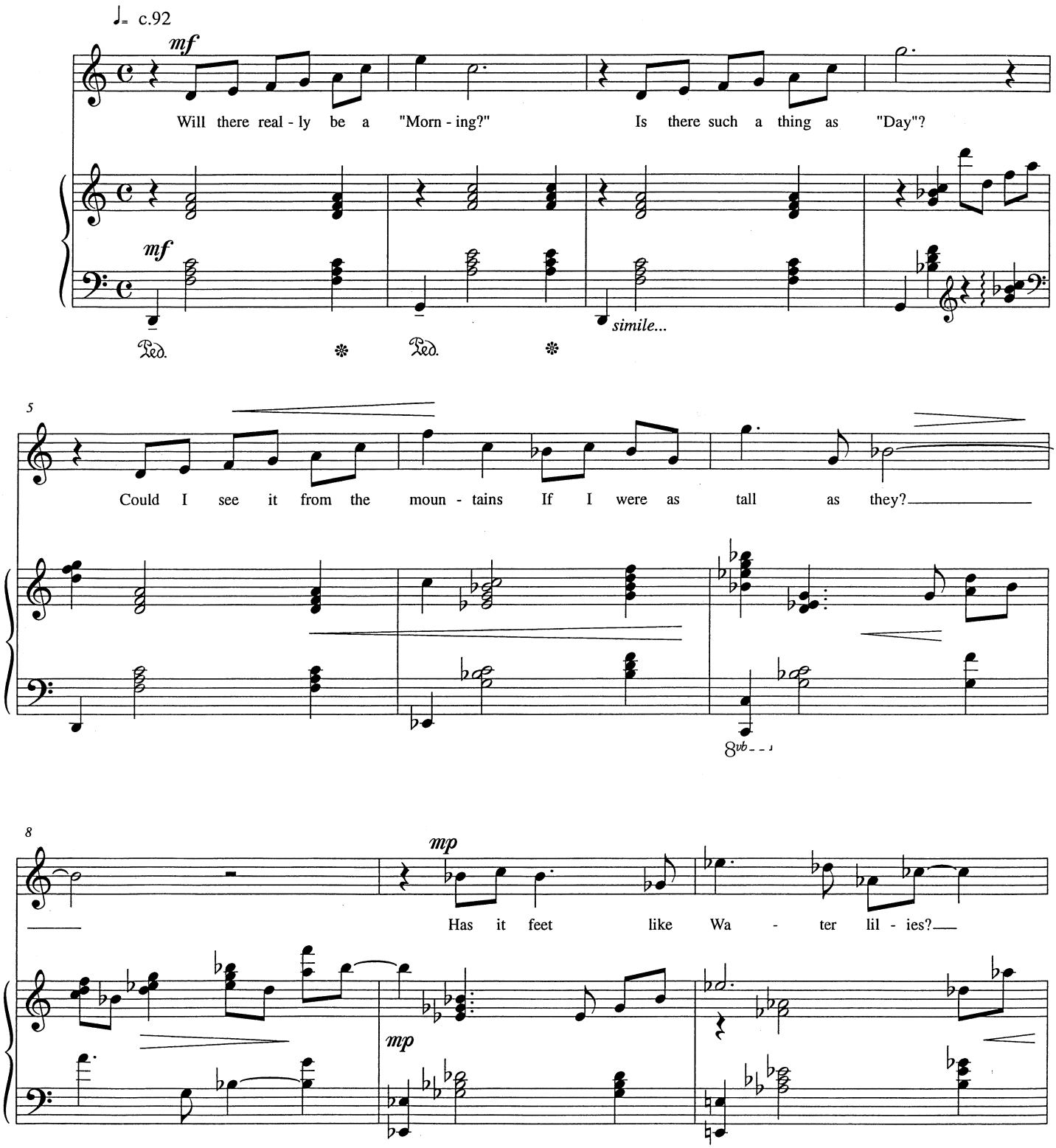
If I can stop one Heart from breaking
I shall not live in vain
If I can ease one Life the Aching
Or cool one Pain

Or help one fainting Robin
Unto his Nest again
I shall not live in Vain.
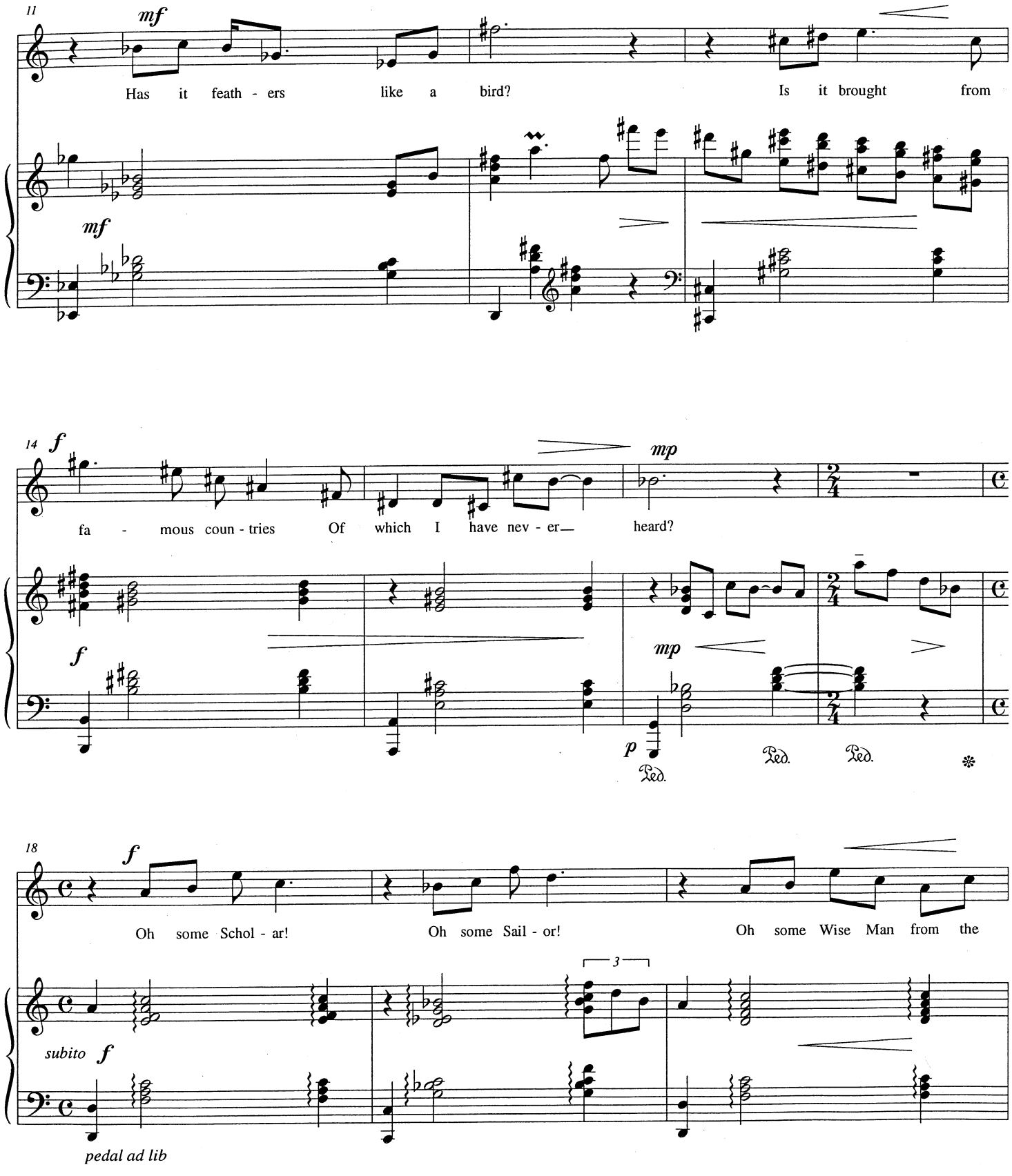
1. Will there really be a Morning?
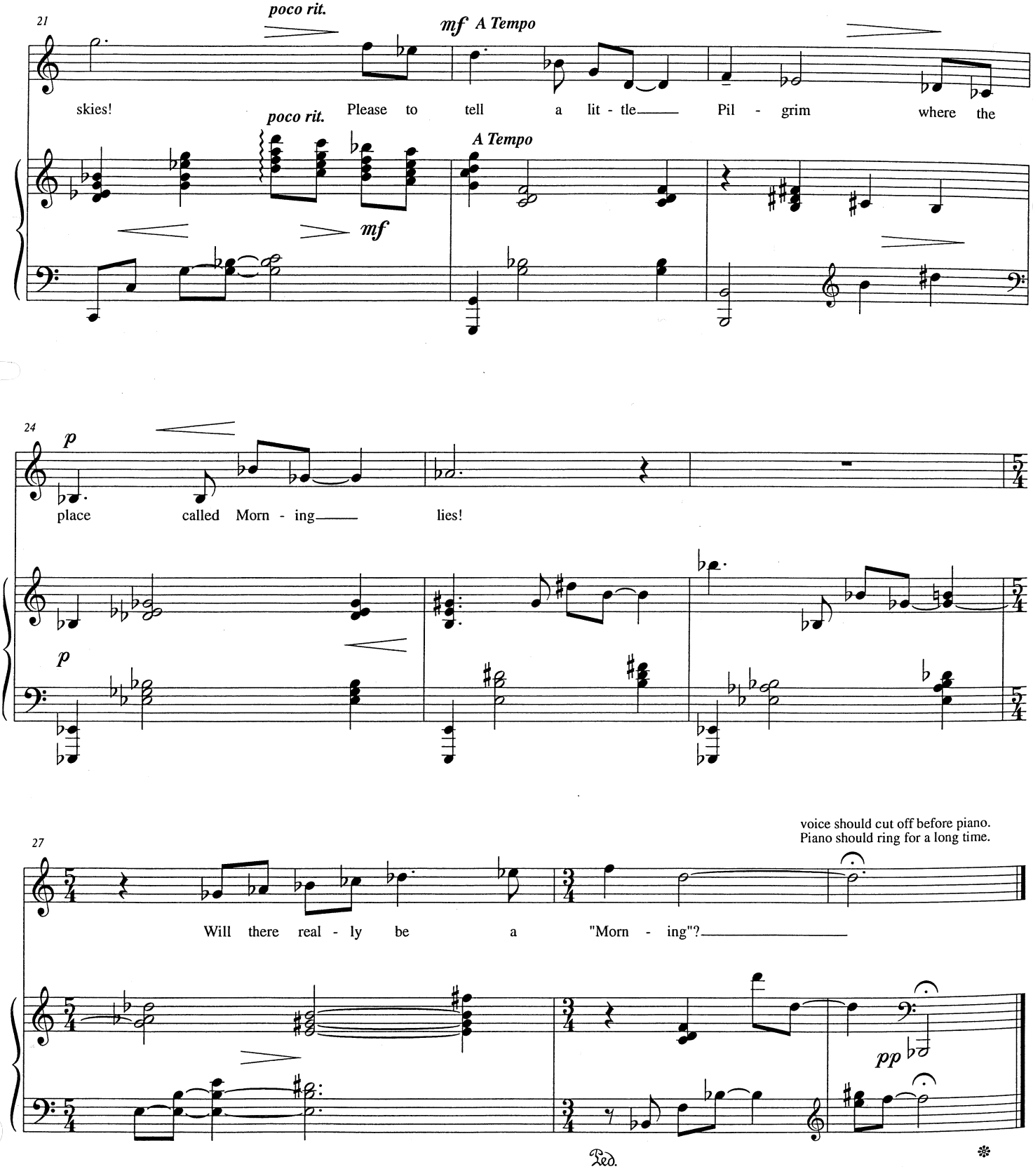
for Karen Bogan

EMILY DICKINSON **LORI LAITMAN**



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11
mf
Has it feath - ers like a bird? Is it brought from
mf
14
f
fa - mous coun - tries Of which I have nev - er— heard?
mp
f
mp
p
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
18
f
Oh some Schol - ar! Oh some Sail - or! Oh some Wise Man from the
3
subito f
pedal ad lib
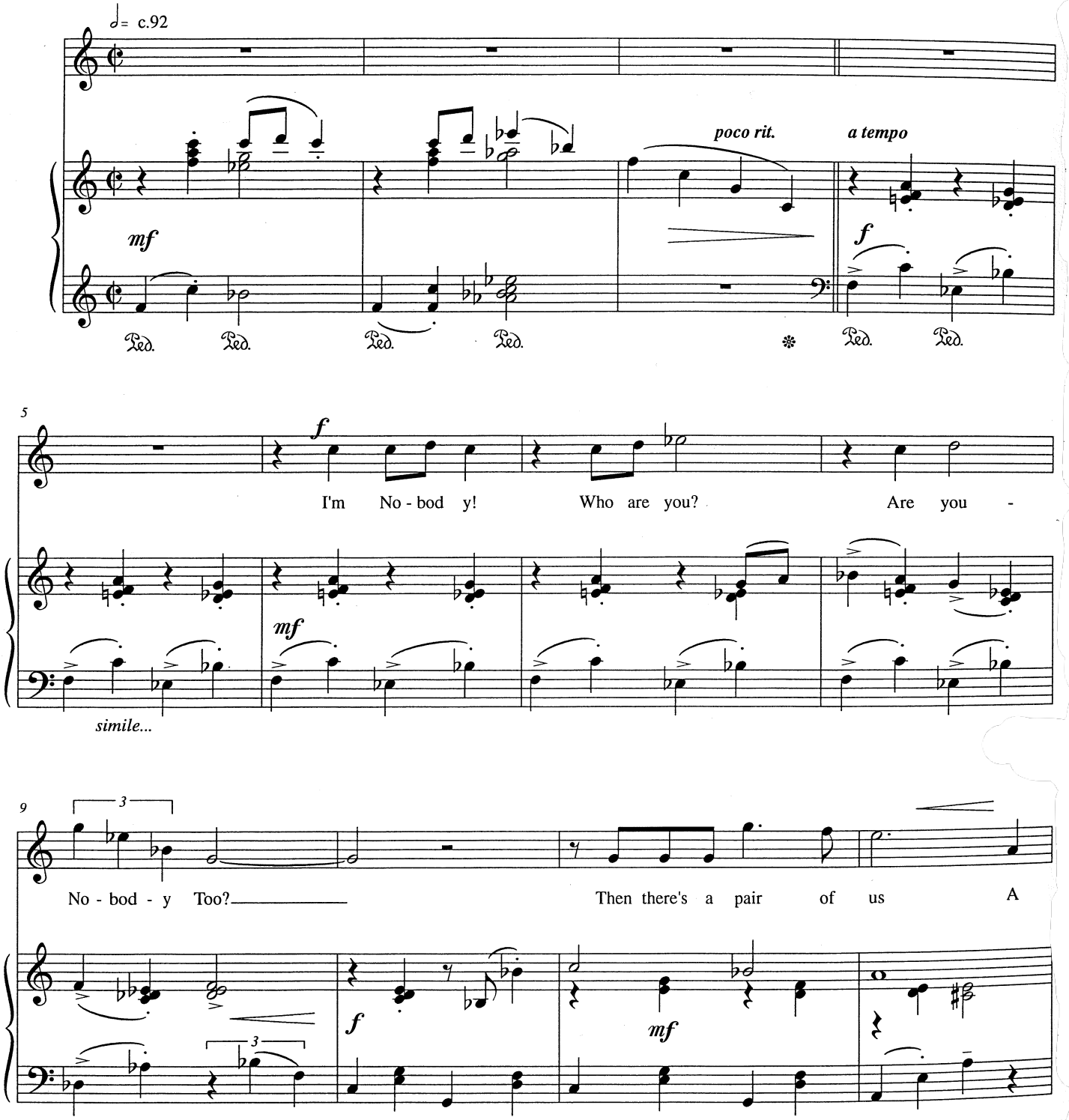

21
poco rit.
mf A Tempo
skies!
poco rit.
Please to tell a lit - tle Pil - grim where the
A Tempo
mf
24
p
place called Morn - ing lies!
p
27
voice should cut off before piano.
Piano should ring for a long time.
Will there real - ly be a "Morn - ing"?
pp
Ped.
*
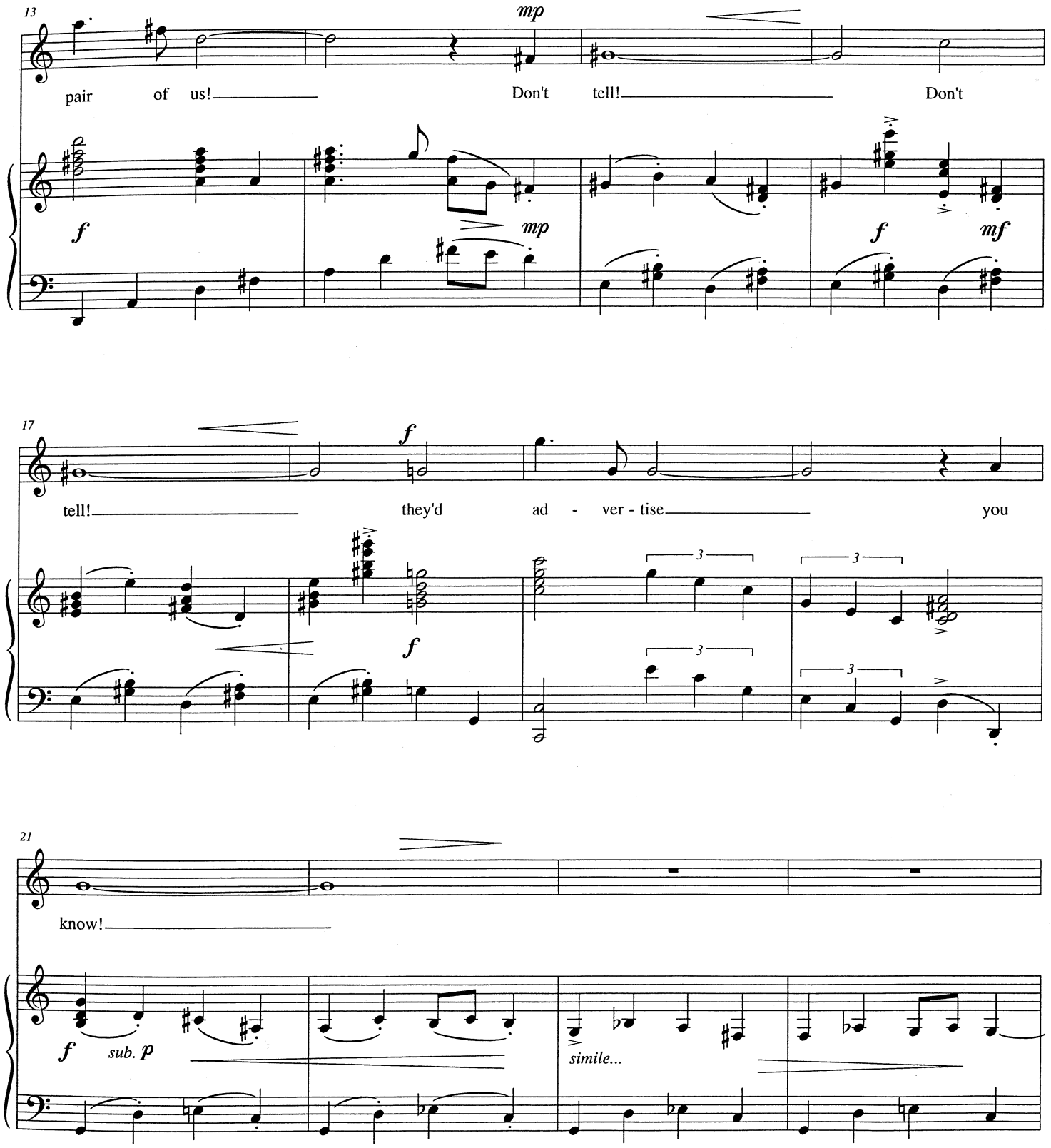
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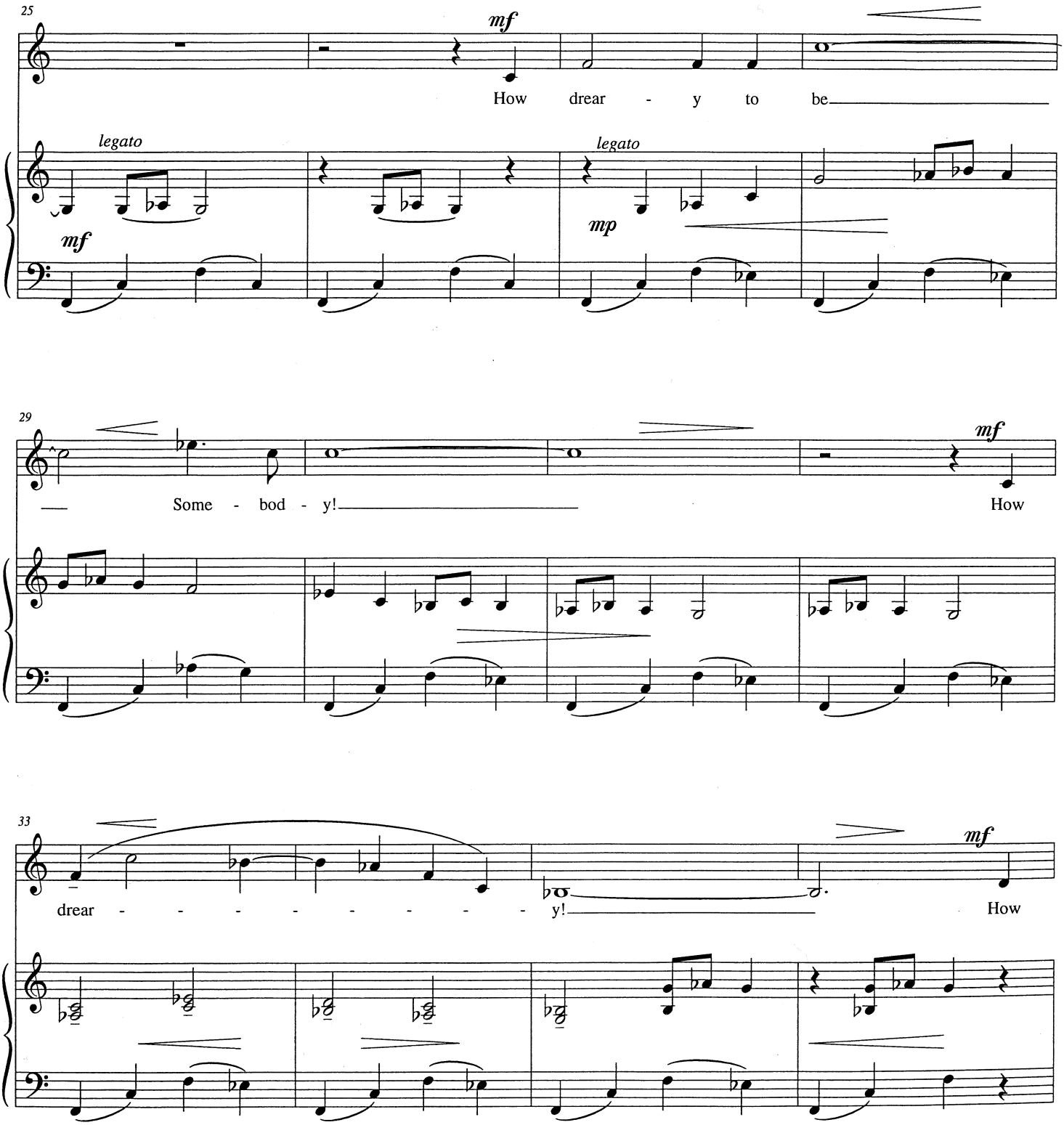
2. I'm Nobody
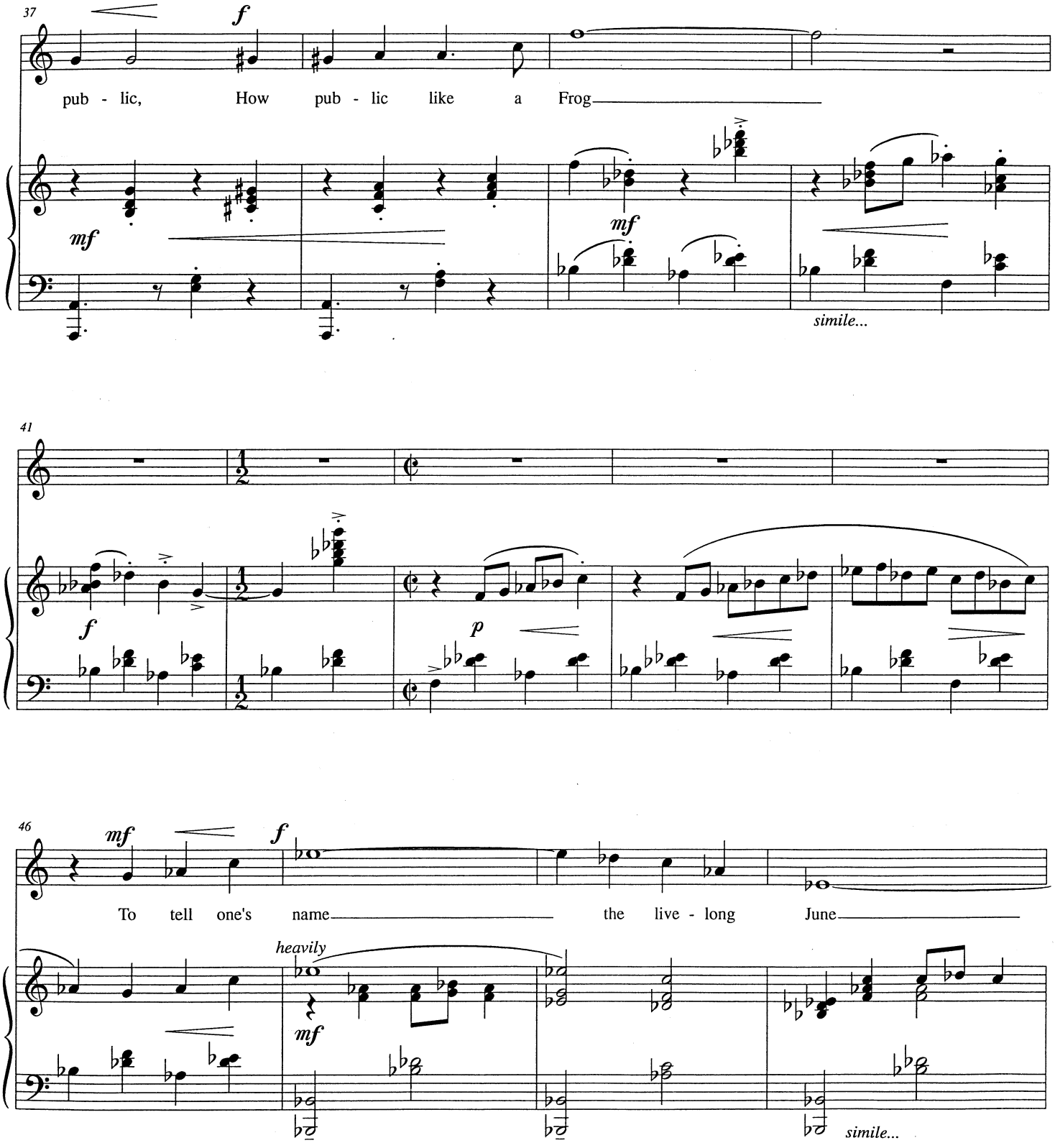
for Karen Bogan
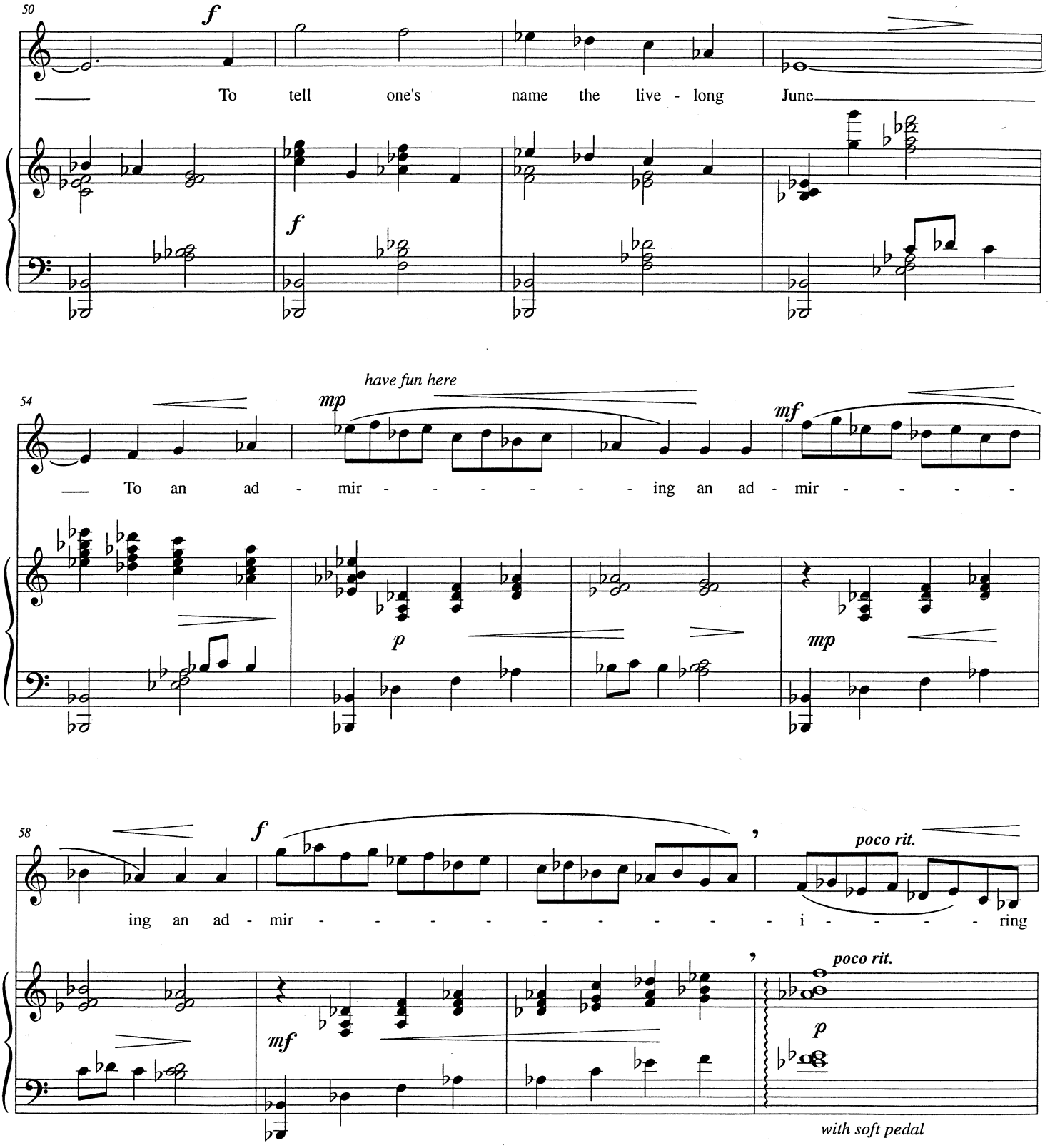
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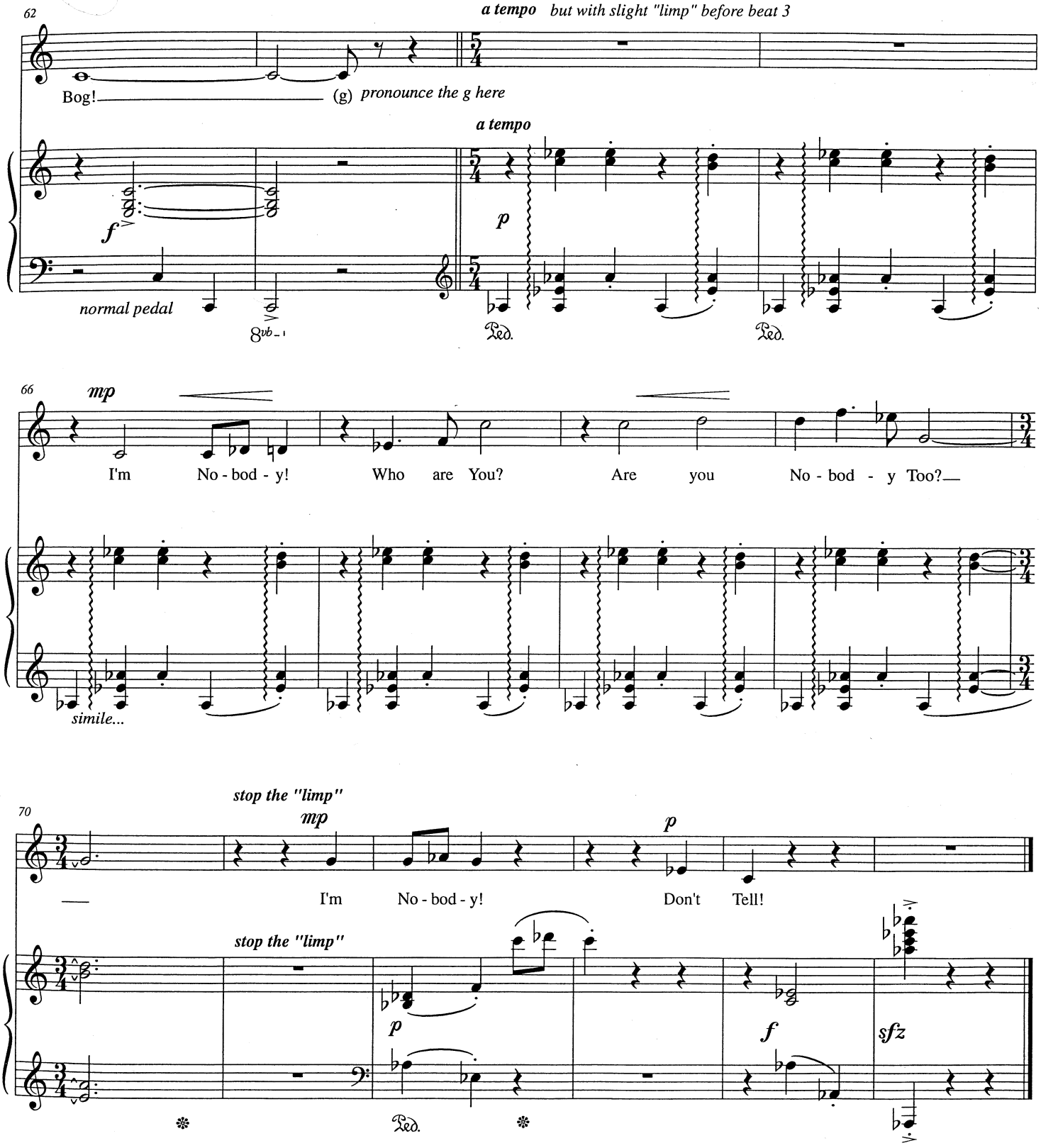



13
mp
pair of us!
Don't tell!
Don't
f
mp
f
mf
17
f
tell!
they'd ad - ver - tise
you
3
3
3
3
f
21
know!
f
sub. p
simile...


25
mf
How drear - y to be
legato
mf
legato
mp
29
Some - bod - y!
mf
How
33
drear - - - - - - - - - y!
mf
How


37
f
pub - lic, How pub - lic like a Frog
mf
mf
simile...
41
f
p
46
mf
f
To tell one's name the live - long June
heavily
mf
simile...


50
f
To tell one's name the live - long June
f
54
have fun here
mp
mf
To an ad - mir - - - - - - - ing an ad - mir - - - -
p
mp
58
f
poco rit.
ing an ad - mir - - - - - - - - - - i - - - - ring
mf
poco rit.
p
with soft pedal
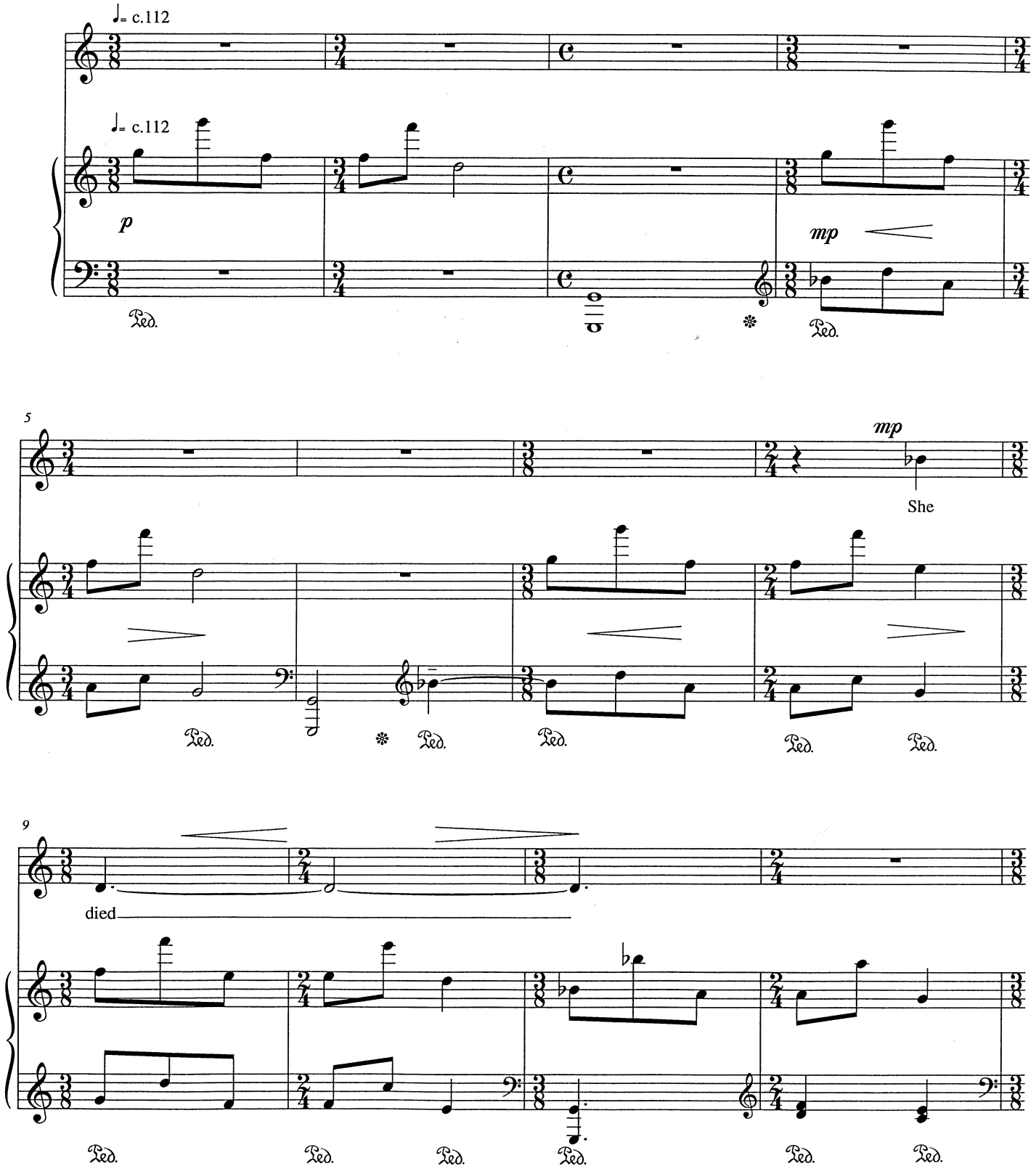

62
a tempo but with slight "limp" before beat 3
Bog! (g) pronounce the g here
a tempo
f
p
normal pedal
8vb
Ped.
Ped.
66
mp
I'm No - bod - y! Who are You? Are you No - bod - y Too?
simile...
stop the "limp"
70
mp
p
I'm No - bod - y! Don't Tell!
stop the "limp"
p
f
sfz
Ped.
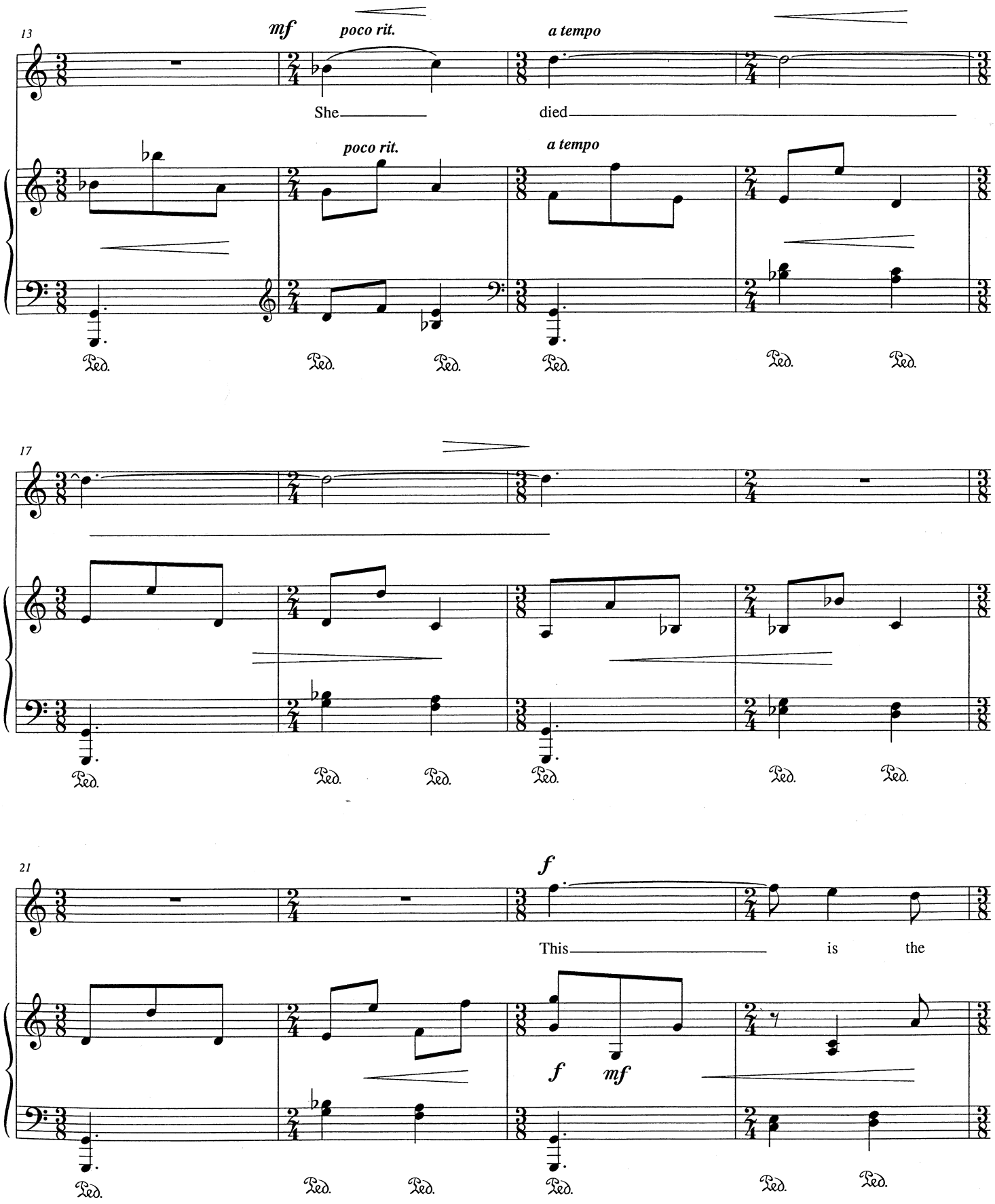
3. She Died
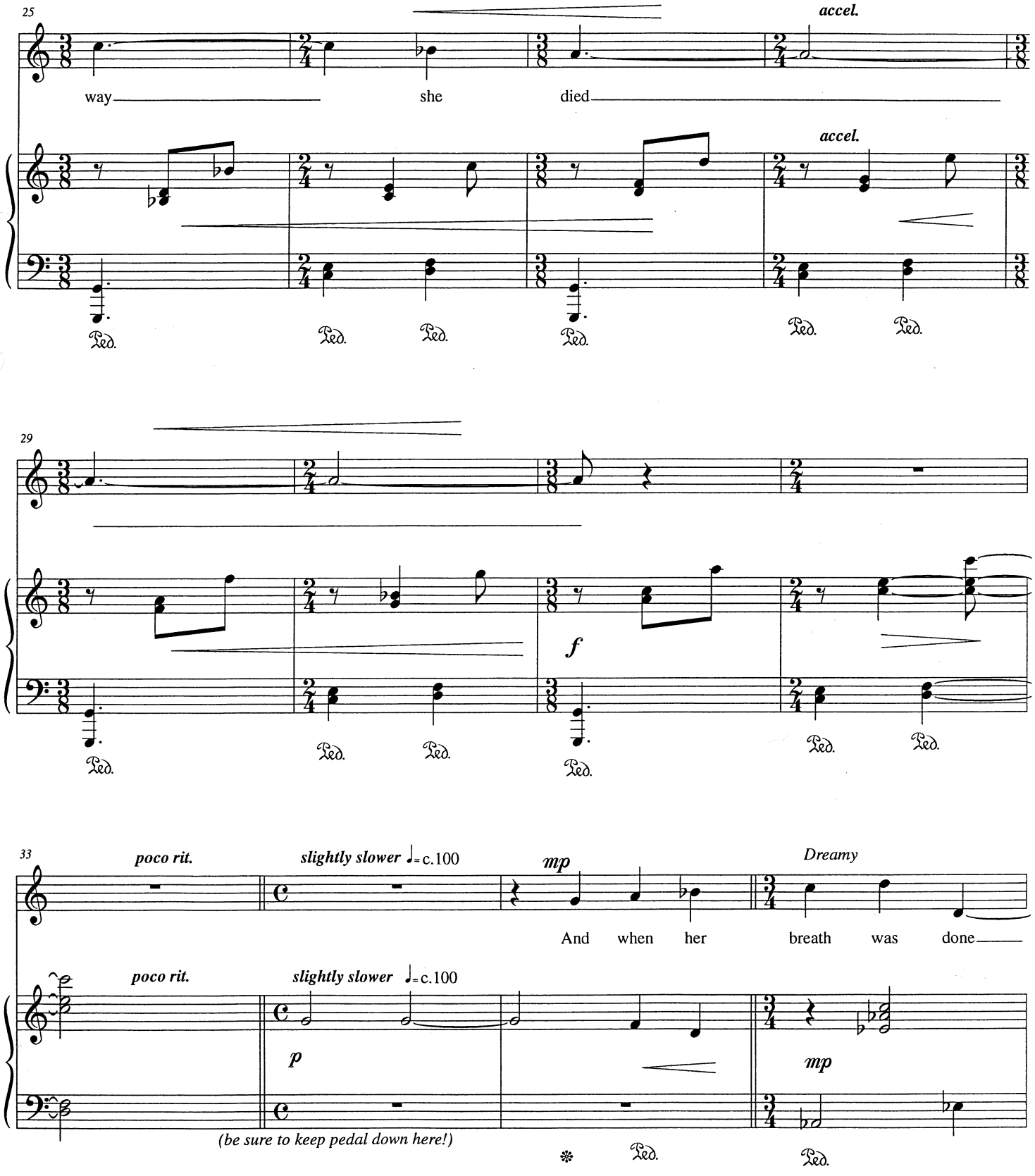
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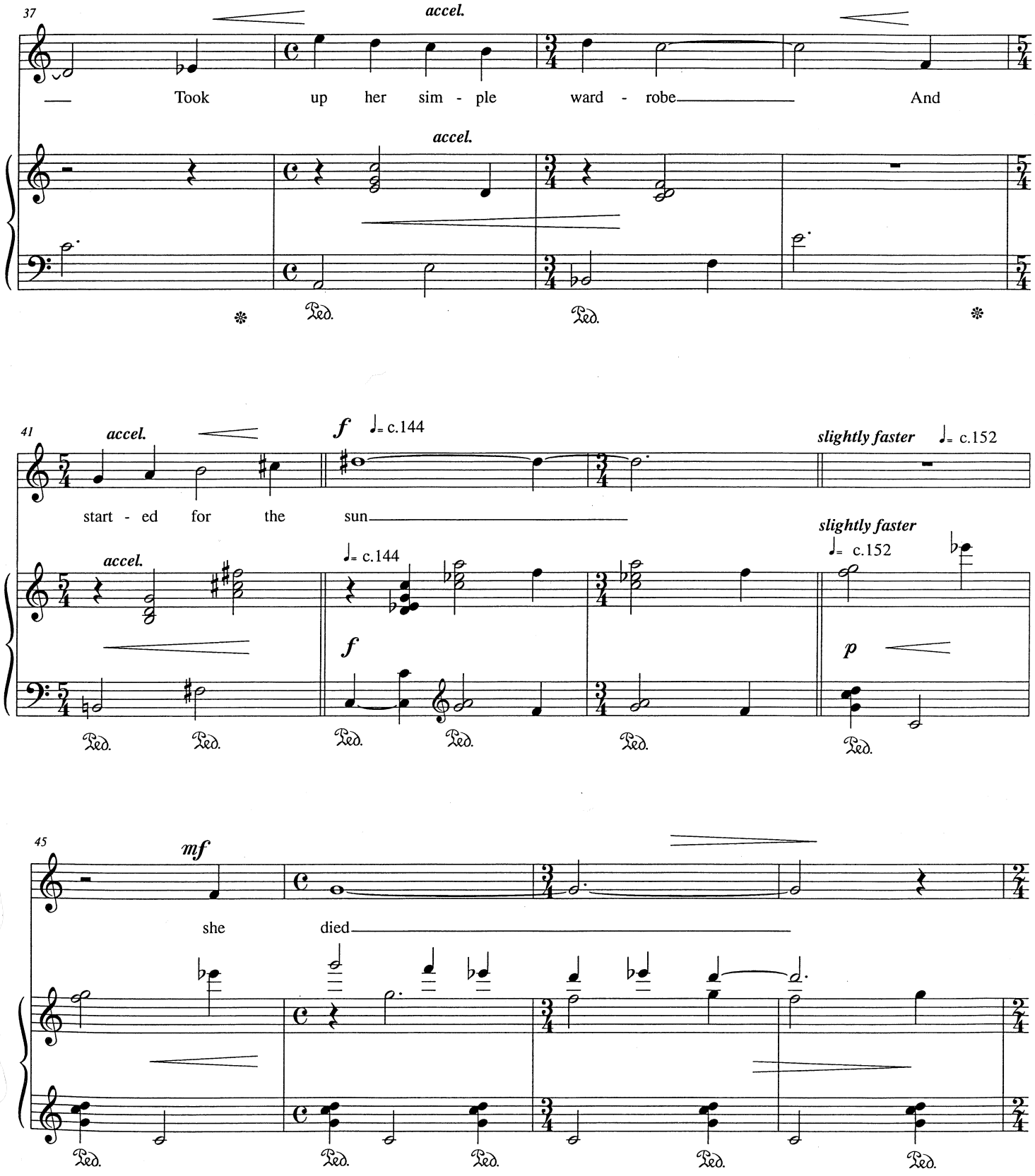
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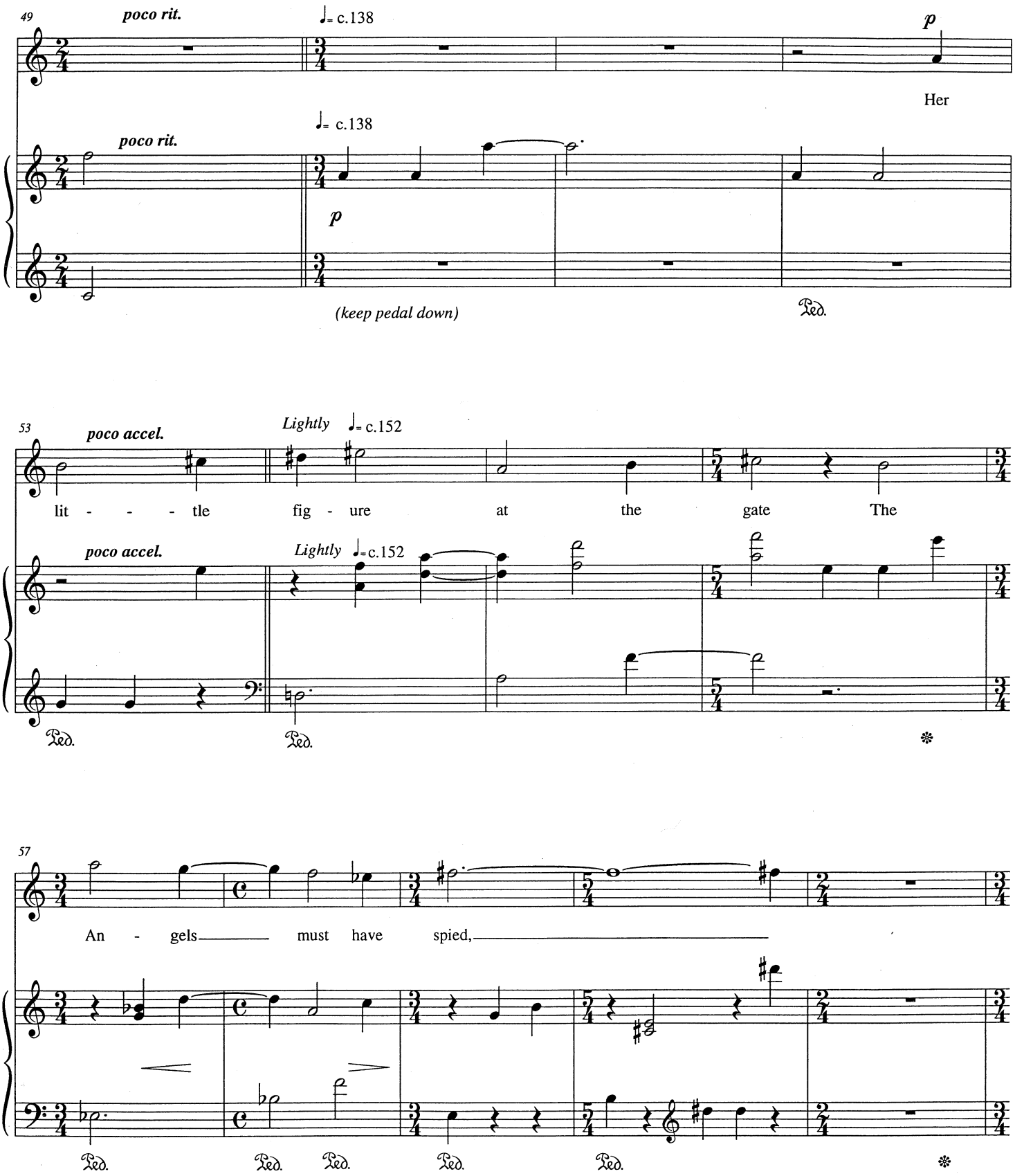
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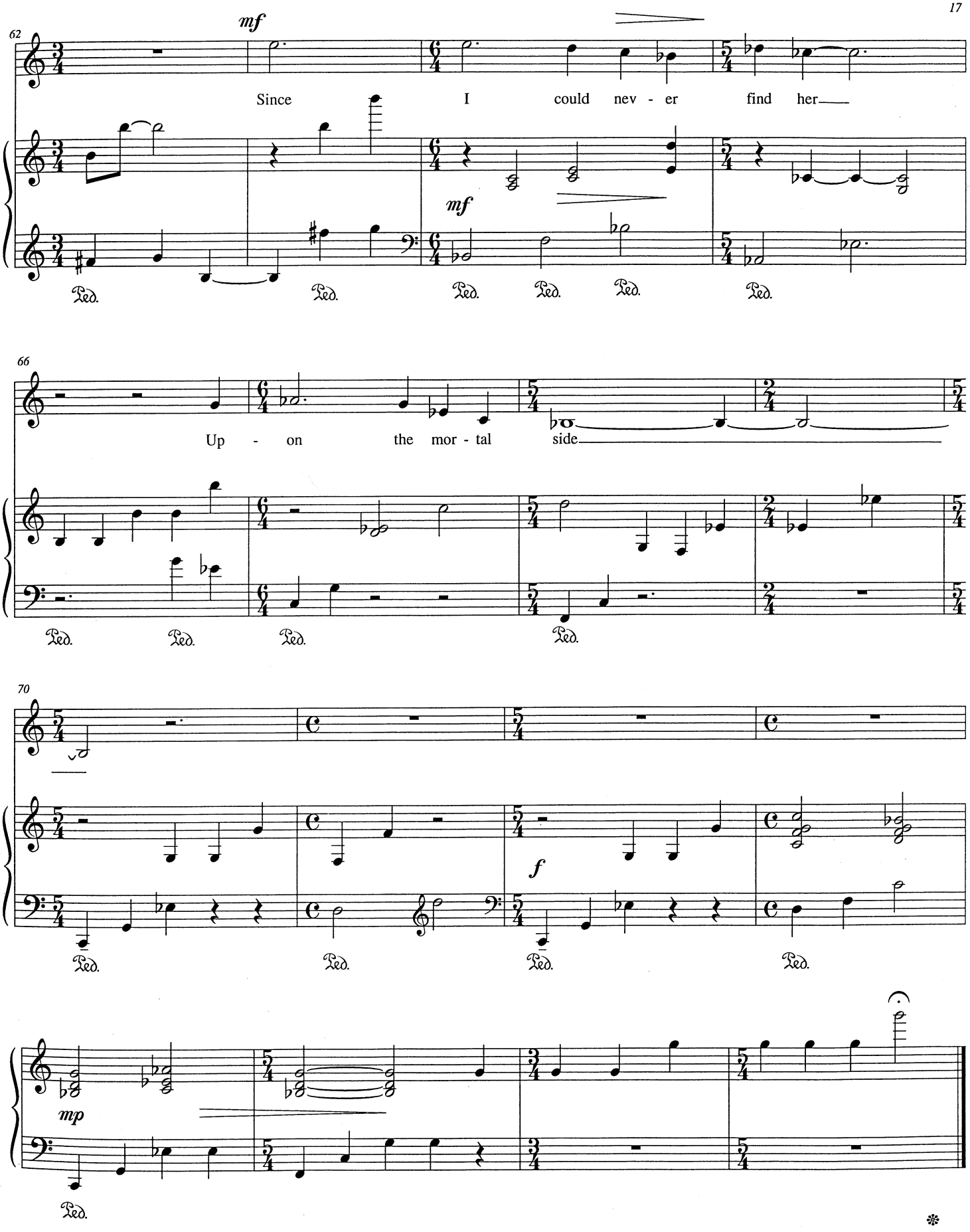



13
mf
poco rit.
a tempo
She
died
poco rit.
a tempo
Ped.
17
21
f
This
is
the
f
mf


25
accel.
way
she
died
accel.
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
29
f
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
33
poco rit.
slightly slower ♩= c.100
mp
Dreamy
And when her breath was done
poco rit.
slightly slower ♩= c.100
p
mp
(be sure to keep pedal down here!)
Ped.
Ped.


37
accel.
Took up her sim - ple ward - robe And
accel.
Ped.
Ped.
41
accel.
f
♩= c.144
start - ed for the sun
slightly faster
♩= c.152
accel.
♩= c.144
f
slightly faster
♩= c.152
p
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
45
mf
she died
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.


49
poco rit.
♩= c.138
p
Her
poco rit.
♩= c.138
p
(keep pedal down)
Ped.
53
poco accel.
Lightly ♩= c.152
lit - - - tle fig - ure at the gate The
poco accel.
Lightly ♩= c.152
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
57
An - gels must have spied,
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
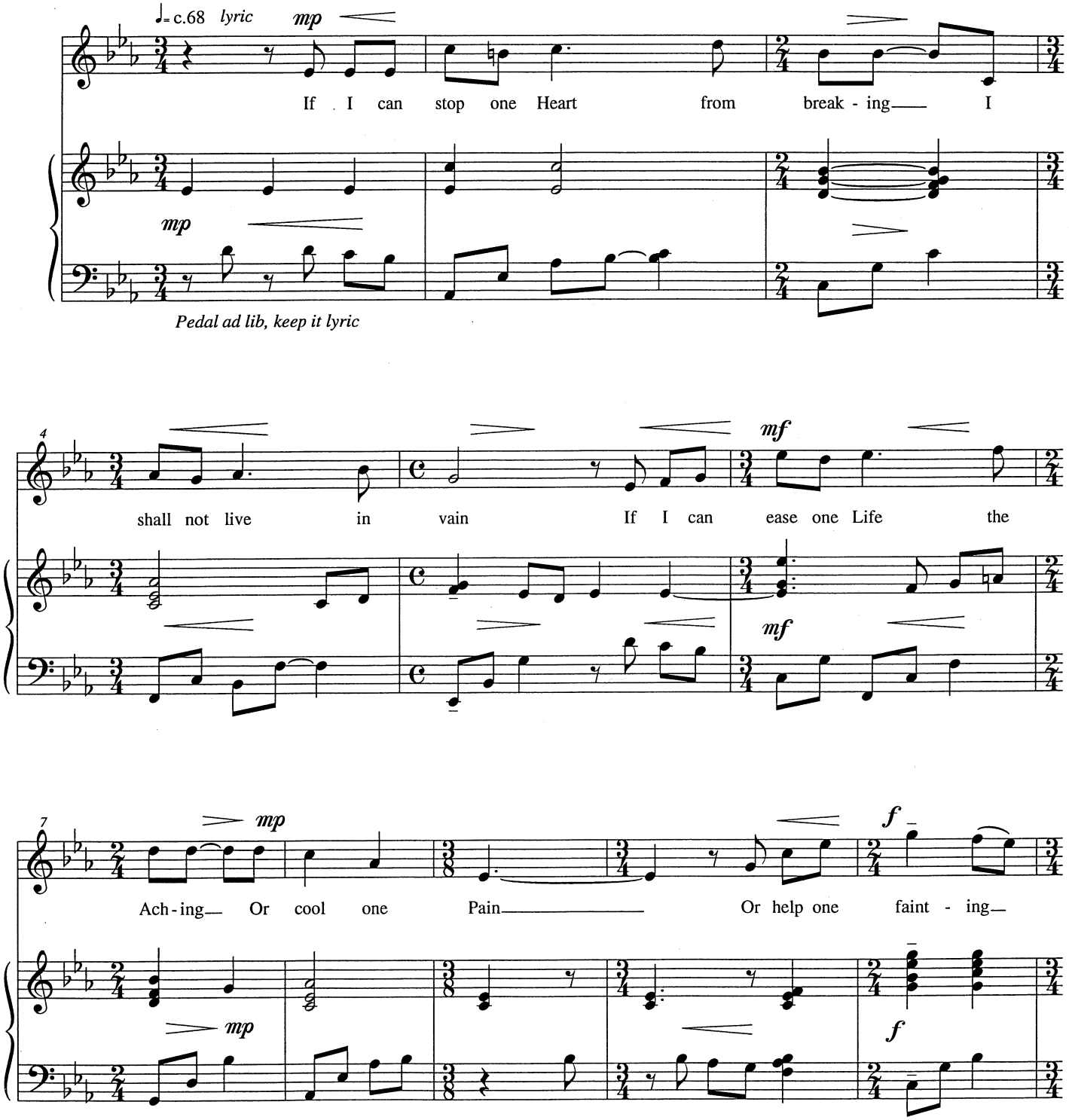

62
mf
Since I could nev - er find her
mf
Ped.
66
Up - on the mor - tal side
70
f
mp
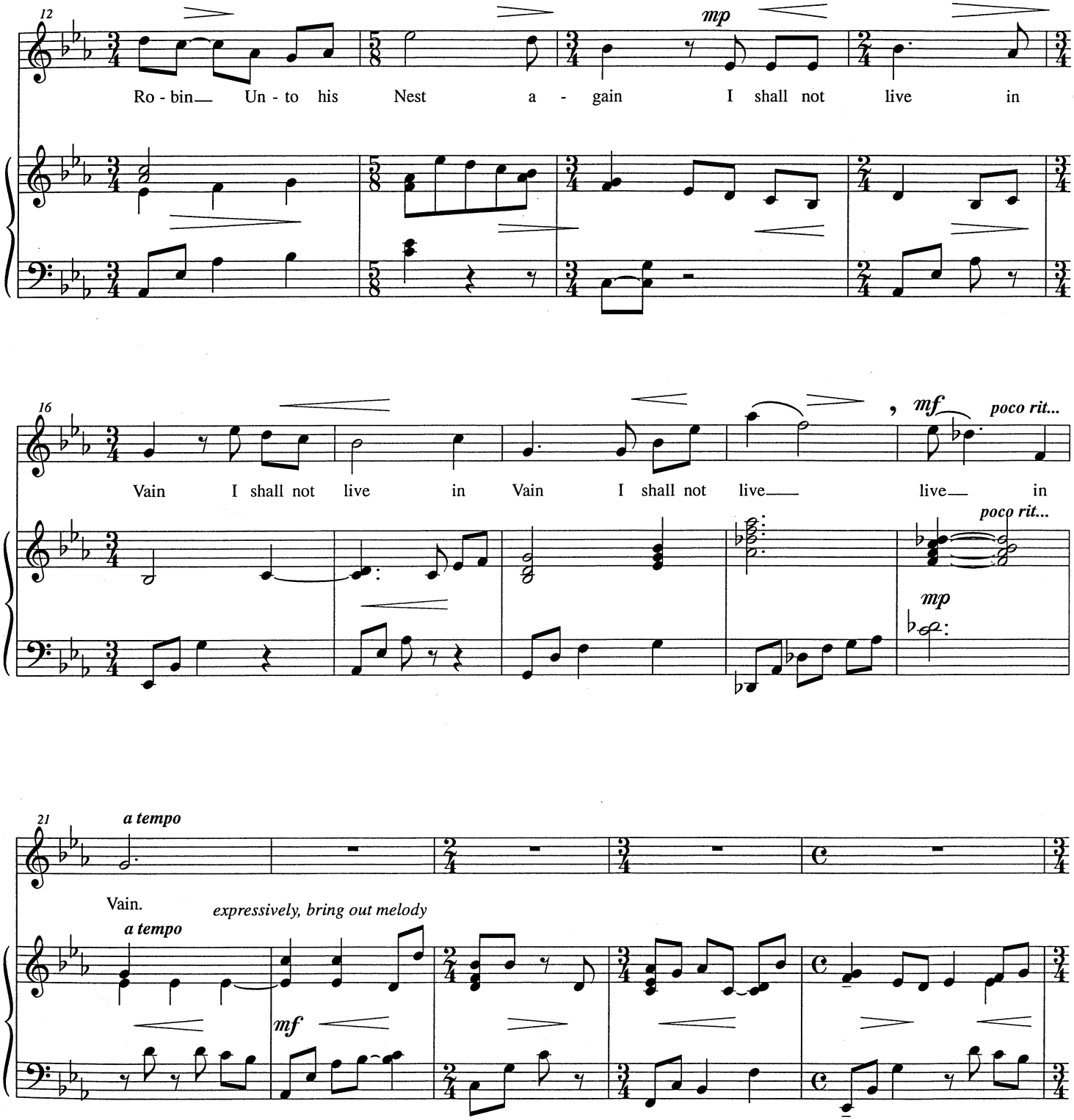
4. If I ...
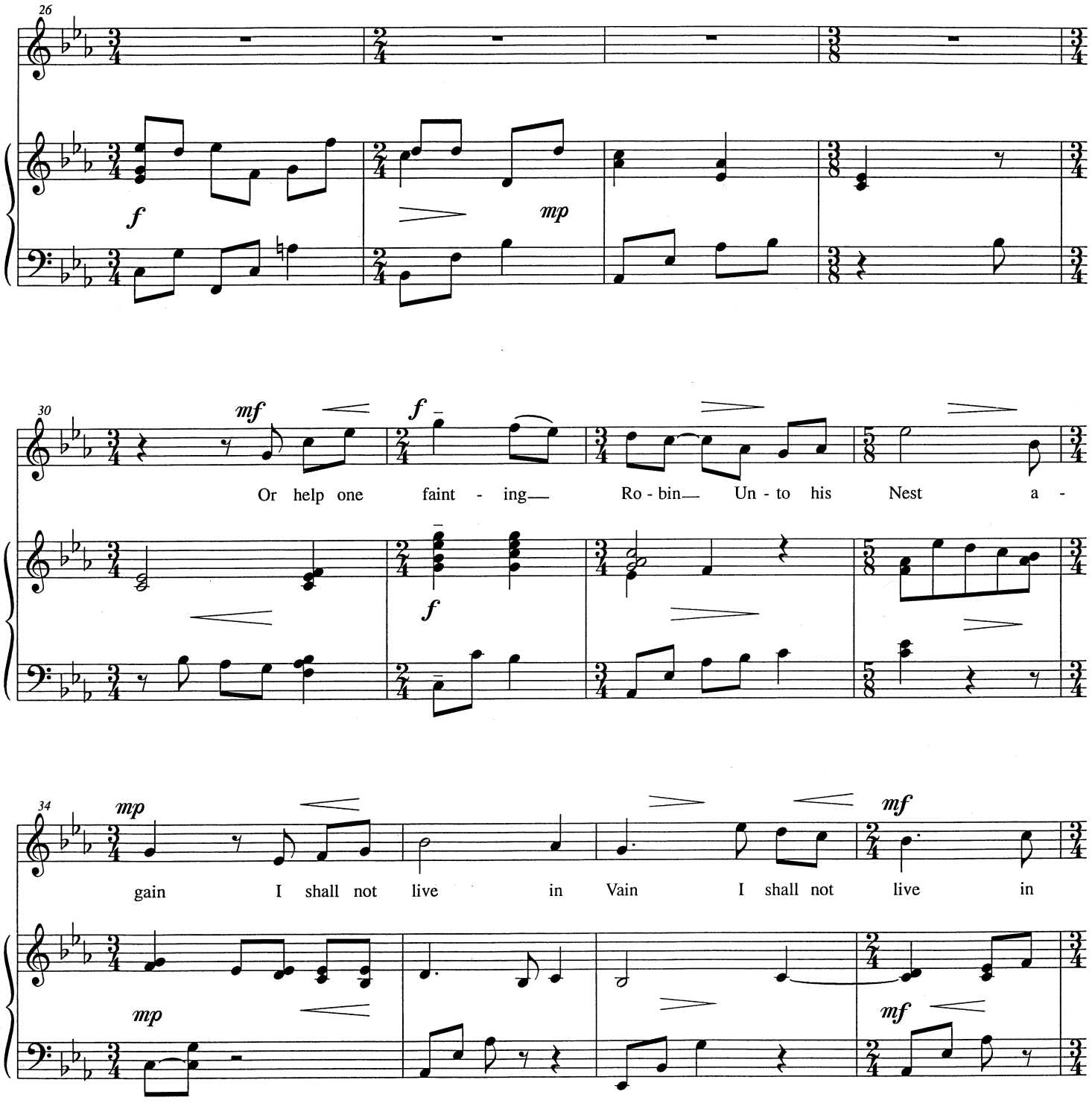
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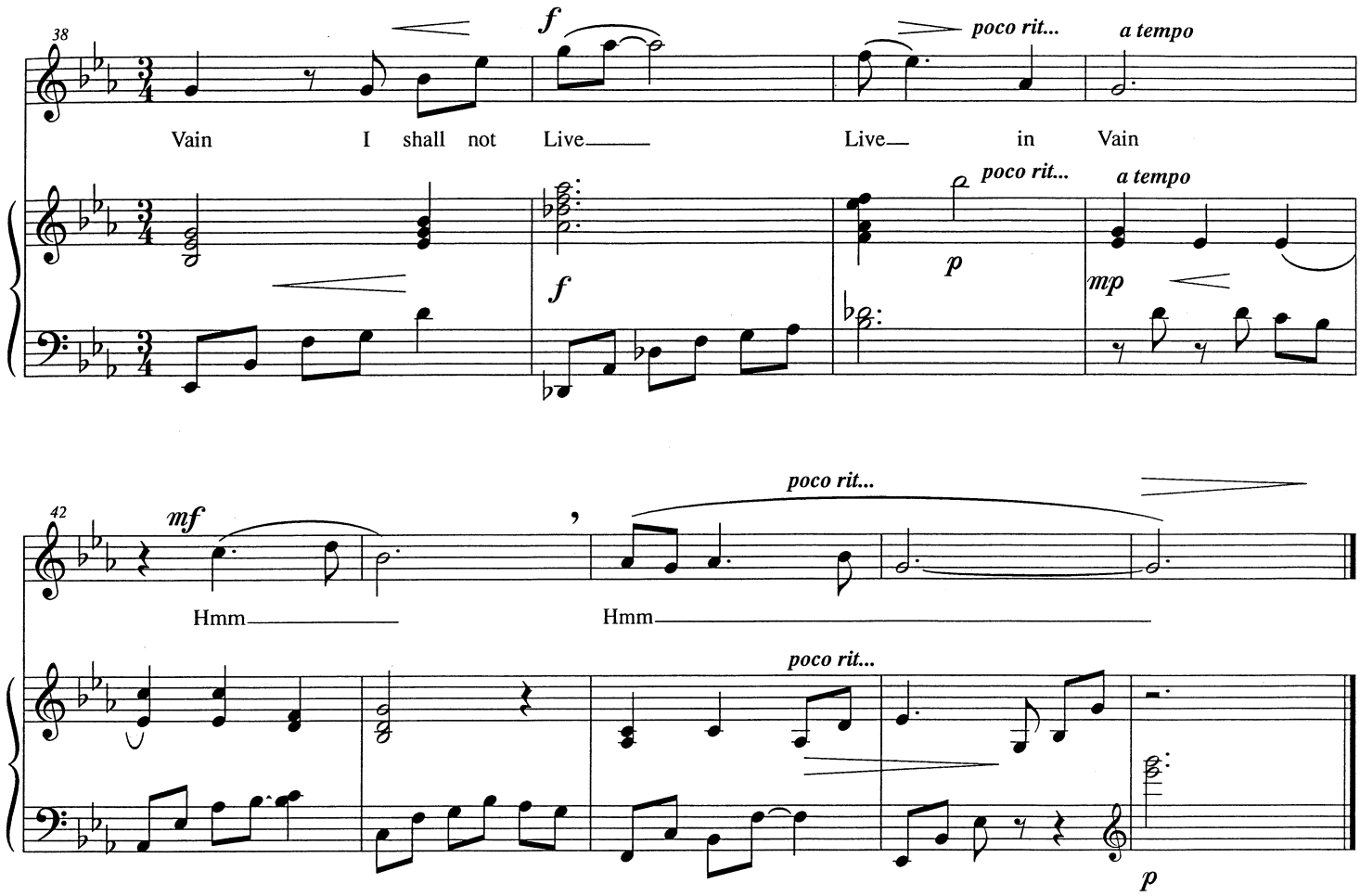
and for Milton Laitman's 80th birthday

EMILY DICKINSON **LORI LAITMAN**




12
mp
Ro - bin— Un - to his Nest a - gain I shall not live in
16
mf
poco rit...
Vain I shall not live in Vain I shall not live— live— in
poco rit...
mp
21
a tempo
Vain.
a tempo
expressively, bring out melody
mf


26
f
mp
30
mf
f
Or help one faint - ing— Ro - bin— Un - to his Nest a -
f
34
mp
gain I shall not live in Vain I shall not live in
mf
mp
mf



The tempo should be somewhat flexible throughout.